

The reckoning of days

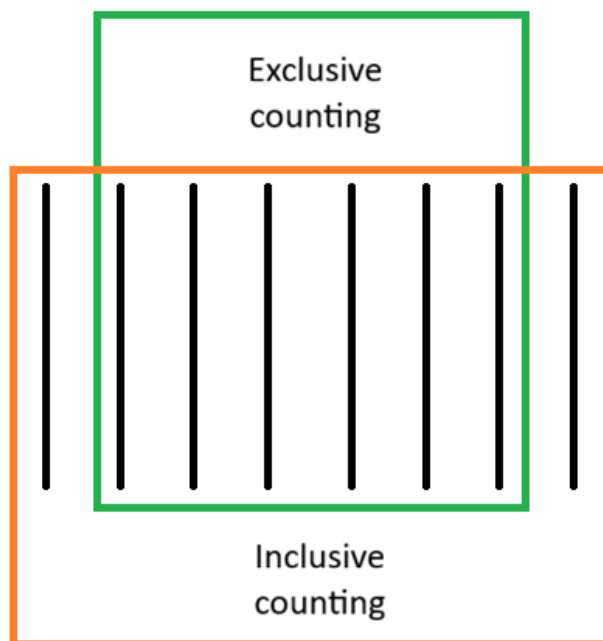
Most people don't realize that there are two different ways of counting days in the Bible. One of them we are used to and one of them we are not. We look at [Matthew 17:1](#), [Mark 9:2](#), and [Luke 9:28](#) which reckon the same time period two different ways and just shrug our shoulders.

Matthew 16:28 Verily I say unto you, There be some standing here, which shall not taste of death, till they see the Son of man coming in his kingdom. Matthew 17:1 ¹ And after six days Jesus taketh Peter, James, and John his brother, and bringeth them up into an high mountain apart,	Mark 9:1 And he said unto them, Verily I say unto you, That there be some of them that stand here, which shall not taste of death, till they have seen the kingdom of God come with power. Mark 9:2 And after six days Jesus taketh with him Peter, and James, and John, and leadeth them up into an high mountain apart by themselves: and he was transfigured before them.	Luke 9:27 But I tell you of a truth, there be some standing here, which shall not taste of death, till they see the kingdom of God. Luke 9:28 And it came to pass about an eight days after these sayings, he took Peter and John and James, and went up into a mountain to pray.
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That's because in modern times we almost exclusively use what is called "exclusive counting". In other words, we express the number of days elapsed *excluding* the first and final day in that count. In the example verses above, both [Matthew](#) and [Mark](#) use exclusive counting which is to say that the day that Jesus spoke and the day that they went into the high mountain are *excluded*.

For example, if I was to say "my birthday is six days from now". The day I spoke it is Day 1 and the day of my birthday would be Day 7. A person hearing me say that would naturally conclude that the day I spoke it and the day of my birthday are both *excluded* from that six days. Generally, exclusive counting requires a full 24-hr period to elapse to be counted as a day.

To say the same thing using *inclusive* counting would be "after eight days it will be my birthday". That is, the day I spoke and the day of my birthday are both now *included* in the count. In the example verses above [Luke](#) uses this inclusive counting method. If [John](#) (which uses inclusive counting otherwise) had a parallel passage to these verses then it would very likely use the same inclusive counting as [Luke](#). In inclusive counting any part of the day is reckoned as a whole day.



So, why is it important to understand the inclusive counting method despite it being so foreign to the way we think in modern times? Very simply, because it's a Hebrew custom and the overwhelming majority of the Bible uses it. Therefore, if we want to understand the Bible more accurately then we necessarily need to understand when and where it uses inclusive counting. And we can do that by looking at the internal evidence of the Bible itself.

Genesis 1:5 (cf. Exodus 20:11)
And God called the light Day, and the darkness he called Night. And the evening and the morning were the first day.

- A Biblical day is “the evening and the morning”.
- In modern times we reckon days the exact opposite: “the morning and the evening”.

Day reckoning in the Old Testament

Exodus 12:15-18
¹⁵ Seven days shall ye eat unleavened bread; even the first day ye shall put away leaven out of your houses: for whosoever eateth leavened bread from the first day until the seventh day, that soul shall be cut off from Israel.
...
¹⁸ In the first month, on the fourteenth day of the month at even, ye shall eat unleavened bread, until the one and twentieth day of the month at even.

We see 21 – 14 = 7 and think that makes sense because it does. But, we might do that without realizing that that calculation is *inclusive* (the first [14] and last day [21] are *included*).

If we used exclusive counting, as we most often do in modern times, that same time period would be described as **six** days. But, God said it was **seven** days. They're actually both right; but, what we're after is which counting method did God use here? Because God said the time period is “seven days” then He clearly used *inclusive* counting.

First month															
Time	Even	Morn	Even	Morn	Even	Morn	Even	Morn	Even	Morn	Even	Morn	Even	Morn	Even
Day	14 th	15 th		16 th		17 th		18 th		19 th		20 th		21 st	
Inclusive	Day 1		Day 2		Day 3		Day 4		Day 5		Day 6		Day 7		
Exclusive		Day 1		Day 2		Day 3		Day 4		Day 5		Day 6			

When does the Bible use exclusive or inclusive counting?

Good question! I haven't yet noticed any easily discernible pattern such as “*only in the new testament*” or “*only in the book of X*” and as such it **must be** determined by the context and all the details given in the Bible. See examples below for examples of both in the old testament.

Jonathan & David

This example serves to show us that inclusive counting is a long standing tradition among Hebrews (remember Jonathan is the son of Saul the son of Benjamin).

1 Samuel 20:12-19

¹² And Jonathan said unto David, O LORD God of Israel, when I have sounded my father about **to morrow** any time, **or the third day**, and, behold, if there be good toward David, and I then send not unto thee, and shew it thee;

...

¹⁹ And when thou hast stayed **three days**, then thou shalt go down quickly, and come to the place where thou didst hide thyself when the business was in hand, and shalt remain by the stone Ezel.

Today	To morrow any time	Or the third day
Day 1	Day 2	Day 3
Jonathan speaks to David	When I have sounded my father	
Three days		

In exclusive counting, we would call this same time period **one** day.

Esther's fast

Esther 4:16 (Esther speaking)

Go, gather together all the Jews that are present in Shushan, and fast ye for me, and neither eat nor drink **three days**, night or day: I also and my maidens will fast likewise; and so will I go in unto the king, which is not according to the law: and if I perish, I perish.

Esther 5:1

Now it came to pass **on the third day**, that Esther put on her royal apparel, and stood in the inner court of the king's house, over against the king's house: and the king sat upon his royal throne in the royal house, over against the gate of the house.

This example makes it very obvious but it's easy to miss if we don't think about it carefully. Using the modern exclusive counting, if they were to fast for three days then Esther would have gone into the king's house on the **fourth** day.

Esther speaks	3 days of fasting			Esther goes into the king's house
	Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4

In order for Esther to have gone into the king's house **on the third** day as she did we would have to use inclusive counting.

Esther speaks (the fasting begins this day)	Full day of fasting	Esther goes into the king's house
Day 1	Day 2	Day 3

Rehoboam

2 Chronicles 10:5-12

5 And he said unto them, Come again unto me **after three days**. And the people departed.

...

12 So Jeroboam and all the people came to Rehoboam **on the third day**, as the king bade, saying, Come again to me on the third day.

Look carefully at the wording “after” and “on”. These are the specific clues we need. “After” three days using modern exclusive counting would mean that the people returned on the **fourth** day.

Rehoboam speaks	3 day waiting period			The people returned
	Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4

But, that’s not what it says. It says specifically that the people came “**on** the third day”. There’s only one way for that to be possible and that’s by using inclusive counting.

Rehoboam speaks	Waiting period	The people return
Day 1	Day 2	Day 3

David’s reign

2 Samuel 5:4-5 (cf. 1 Kings 2:11, 1 Chronicles 29:27)

⁴ David was thirty years old when he began to reign, and he reigned **forty years**.

⁵ In Hebron he reigned over Judah **seven years and six months**; and in Jerusalem he reigned **thirty and three years** over all Israel and Judah.

In inclusive counting, his reign length would be reckoned as 41 years. Instead, we see 40 years in three different verses.

Jesus’ resurrection

Once we understand inclusive counting (any part of the day counts as one day), which is the predominant method that the Bible reckons days, the resurrection of Jesus becomes trivial to understand.

Friday	Saturday	Sunday
Jesus dies on the cross at 3PM Matthew 27:45-46,50 Mark 15:33-34,37 Luke 23:44-46 (Mark 15:42 + John 19:14)	The Sabbath John 19:31-33 Mark 15:42-43 Luke 23:52-54	The first day of the week (resurrection day) Matthew 28:1 Mark 16:1-2
Day 1	Day 2	Day 3

If we were to use modern exclusive counting, then we would say that He arose “**on** the second day” (on the day after one full day has passed) or “**after** one day” (one full day elapsed). They’re all correct, they are just different ways of counting the same time period.

References to the three days of Jesus' resurrection

Reference	Exact Phrasing	Categorization	Internal Context / Logic
Matthew 12:40	"three days and three nights"	Inclusive OT Reference	Explicitly cites the "sign of the prophet Jonas."
Matthew 16:21	"be raised again the third day"	Inclusive	Jesus' own prophecy using the ordinal "third."
Matthew 17:23	"the third day he shall be raised"	Inclusive	Positional day of the resurrection.
Matthew 20:19	"the third day he shall rise again"	Inclusive	Positional day of the resurrection.
Matthew 26:61	"to build it in three days"	Inclusive	False witnesses quoting Jesus' claim about the Temple.
Matthew 27:40	"buidest it in three days"	Inclusive	Mockery at the cross regarding the Temple.
Matthew 27:63	"After three days I will rise again"	Exclusive	The Pharisees quoting Jesus. In Matthew's exclusive style, "after" marks the boundary.
Matthew 27:64	"until the third day"	Inclusive	The Pharisees' request for the guard. Reconciles v.63.
Mark 8:31	"after three days rise again"	Exclusive	Mark's consistent style for intervals (similar to Mark 9:2).
Mark 9:31	"he shall rise the third day"	Inclusive	Direct reference to the day of the event.
Mark 10:34	"the third day he shall rise again"	Inclusive	Direct reference to the day of the event.
Mark 14:58	"within three days I will build another"	Inclusive	Witnesses quoting Jesus' Temple statement.
Mark 15:29	"buidest it in three days"	Inclusive	Mockery at the cross.
Luke 9:22	"be raised the third day"	Inclusive	Luke's consistent inclusive counting method.
Luke 18:33	"the third day he shall rise again"	Inclusive	Luke's consistent inclusive counting method.
Luke 24:7	"the third day rise again"	Inclusive	The angels reminding the women of Jesus' words.
Luke 24:21	"to day is the third day"	Inclusive	The most explicit proof: Day 1 (Friday) to Day 3 (Sunday).
Luke 24:46	"to rise from the dead the third day"	Inclusive	Jesus explaining the fulfillment of "it is written."
John 2:19	"in three days I will raise it up"	Inclusive	John's consistent inclusive counting method.
1 Corinthians 15:4	"rose again the third day"	Inclusive	Paul's theological summary of the event.